



School Leadership · Session 2

Understanding Autistic Experience:

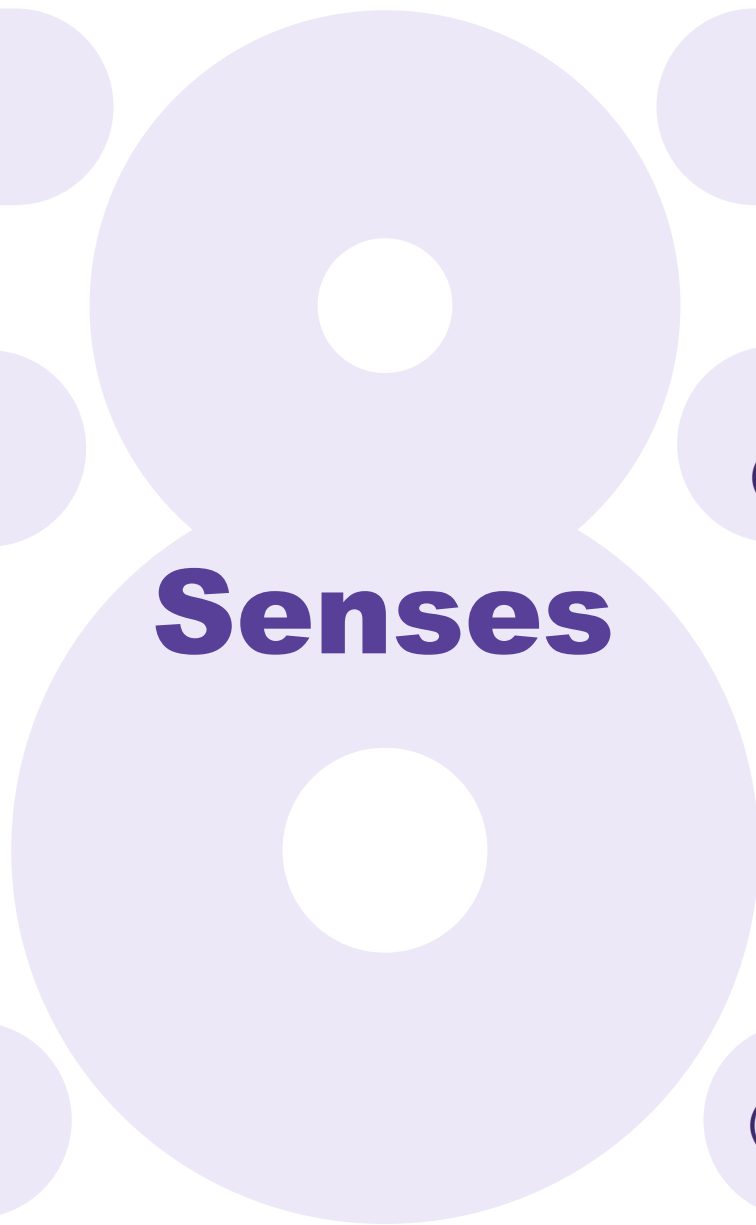
Sensory and Thinking

Sensory





What is sensory processing?



Senses



Touch



Smell



Vision

Proprioception
(Sense of body in space)



Gustatory
(Oral sensations)

Vestibular (Balance)



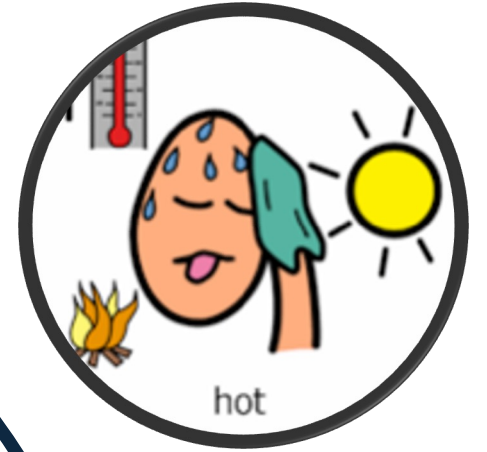
Hearing

Interoception
(Sense of internal
body signals)





**Sensory
Information**



Sensory processing

**Reaction or
Response**

Processing





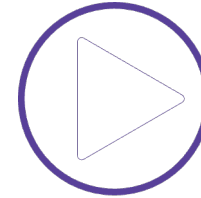
What can sensory processing
differences feel like?

Overwhelm.





Well, I can see that interaction



What can sensory processing
differences feel like?

Joy.

Sensory joy and stimming

Sensory experience can include pleasure, connection and regulation as well as discomfort or overload.

1 Notice sensory joy

2 Recognise stimming and authentic expression

3 Avoid treating difference as disruption by default

4 Ask what students want others to understand



Registration

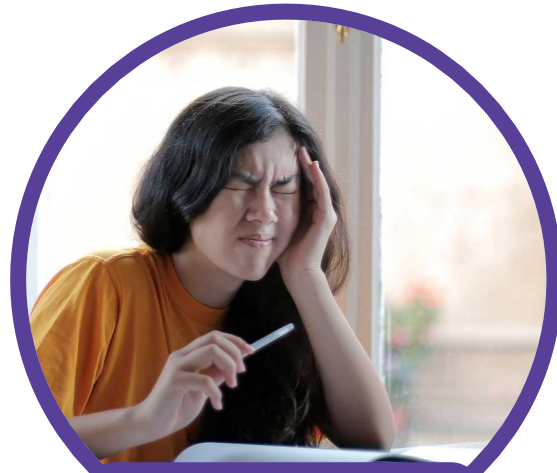


Under responsive



**Sensory
Seeking**

The 4 sensory profiles



**Sensory
Sensitive**



Over responsive



**Sensory
Avoiding**

Sensory activity

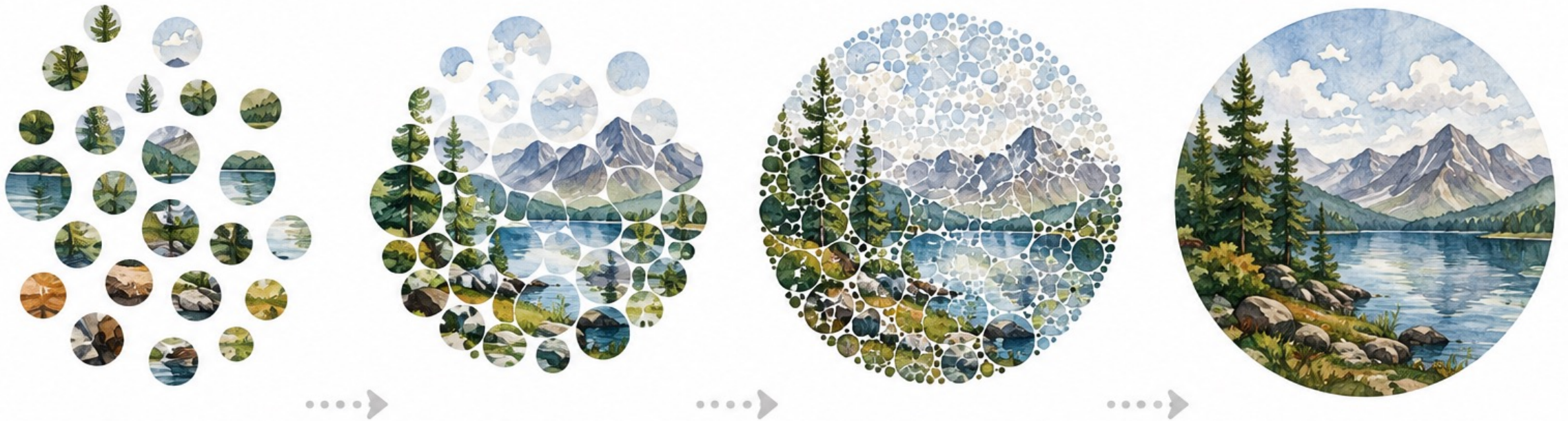
Choose one familiar classroom routine. What sensory demands does the environment or task create, and what options could increase access or choice?

- 1 Name the routine without identifying a student or school.
- 2 List environmental and task demands before listing student responses.
- 3 Add possible options, including ways a student might communicate what helps.
- 4 Mark each option as a question to explore rather than an assumed solution.

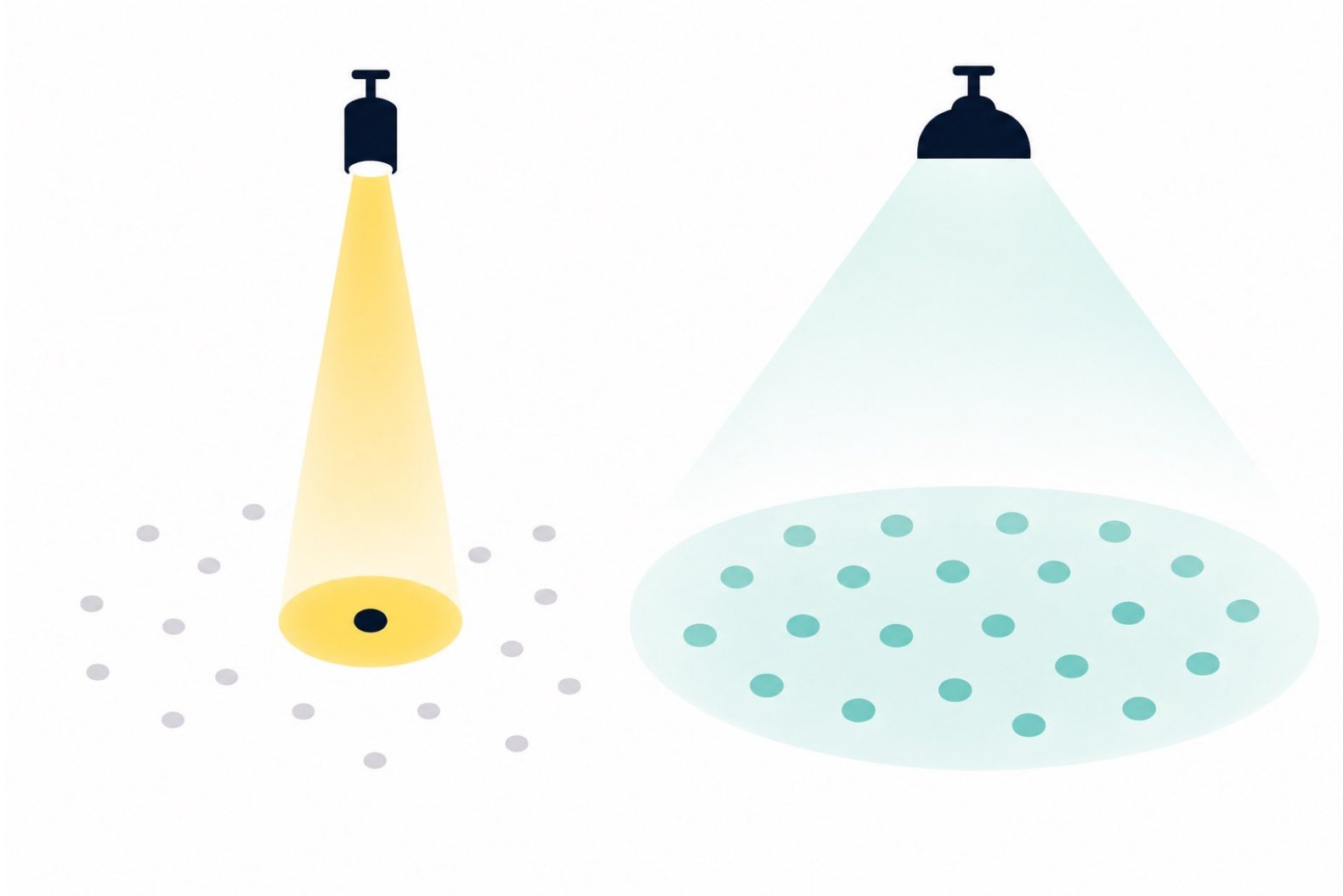


Thinking

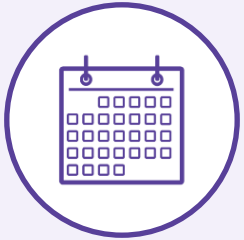
The Detail-First Brain



The Deep Focus Brain



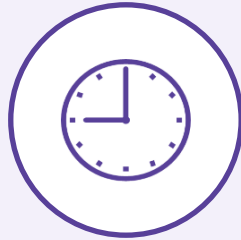
Executive Functioning



Planning



Organisation



**Time
management**



Working memory



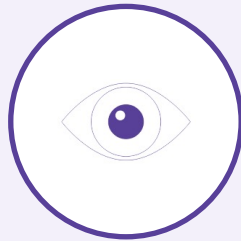
Meta-cognition
(thinking about our own
thinking)



**Emotional
regulation**



Flexibility



Attention



Task initiation



Persistence

Executive functioning example

Getting started on a task

Detail-First Brain

Starting can be hard when the whole task is not clear yet.

Some students may not be able to identify the first step they need to take to get started.



Executive functioning example

Switching focus



Deep Focus Brain

It can be difficult for some students to stop what they are doing and switch focus.

Transitions and unexpected interruptions can feel big because the mind is deeply focused on a task - it can feel like 'tunnel vision' for the mind.



How can Autistic thinking feel?

Video placeholder:
young person talking about what it
feels like to focus on something /
hard to transition / tendril-theory



Discussion activity



- What deep interests do the students you have in mind have?
- What do you notice when they are fully engaged, and does it look the same for each of them?
- When during the school day do they have trouble getting started or shifting their attention?
- Have you seen any of them fully absorbed in something at school? What were they doing?

Internal signals



Making sense of what's happening inside

Interoception

Understanding our body's internal signals

Temperature

Hunger

Thirst

Do I need the bathroom?



Alexithymia

Difficulty identifying and describing emotions and feelings

Am I excited or am I anxious?

Is crying always sadness?

What is my friend feeling?

Reading the signs:

Building understanding together

Sometimes students experience a build-up inside, but the surface does not show it.

The more we understand a student's early signs, the less we wait for distress to become obvious.

Building a shared 'map' of these signs with each student, their family and other staff can help everyone respond in a more consistent way.



Discussion activity



- What signs might you notice at school before one of these students becomes overwhelmed? Are they the same for each?
- What would be useful for other staff, and families, to know about these signs?



After Morning Tea

Communication, connection and managing daily capacity

